Reflective Commentary

The Psychology of Performance (CLCC60011)

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I sat staring at my poker tracking software one evening, watching my results graph slope downwards. I had just paid off an obvious river raise (a large final-round bet that almost always signals a very strong hand) with a single pair, losing every chip in front of me. The decision had been mine alone; the money was lost through how I thought, not how the cards fell. I closed the laptop with the recognition that, despite years of playing cards, I had never truly learned the game.

I grew up playing loose, laughing home games of poker with friends: no strategy, no study, just bravado and luck. I considered myself decent at cards, yet I never improved, and the games eventually faded from my life. This May I returned with a purpose: I want a career in trading, and poker struck me as a training ground for the same skills, decision-making under uncertainty, risk management, and emotional control with money at stake. I deposited fifty pounds on an online poker site, and what began as casual play quickly became something deliberate. Over three months, I climbed from the smallest online cash-game stakes (2NL, named for its two-pound buy-in, the cost of a full stack of chips) to 50NL, and in early August I placed fourth of eighty-two in a live tournament at a local casino. It was not merely getting better at poker; it was a performance: "the execution of an action; something accomplished." Three concepts from performance psychology help explain what I learned about myself as a performer: deliberate practice, goal setting, and the experience of flow under pressure.

From Casual Play to Deliberate Practice

Looking back, my home-game poker was play, not practice. There was no structure, no feedback, no effortful repetition at the edge of my ability. K. A. Ericsson, Krampe and Tesch-Römer (1993) define deliberate practice as structured activities designed to improve performance through immediate feedback and sustained effort beyond current competence. In Gagné (2004)'s Differentiated Model of Giftedness and Talent, I may have possessed natural aptitude (a "gift"), but without systematic training, that gift was never transformed into talent.

When I returned in May, everything changed. I adopted a disciplined thinking framework: before every decision, I asked what range of hands my opponent could hold and what price the pot was offering me. I drilled preflop charts (tables showing which starting hands to play from each seat) for twenty minutes daily until those decisions became automatic. Rather than dabbling across formats, I committed to one, six-player no-limit hold'em cash games, before expanding. I studied Peter Clarke's *The Grinder's Manual* and practised the arithmetic of pot odds (the price a bet offers against the chance of winning) until it felt like times tables. A typical day meant range drills, a focussed ninety-minute session, and thirty minutes reviewing the hands I had marked as difficult. A. Ericsson and Pool (2016) emphasise that what distinguishes deliberate practice from repetition is the development of "mental representations" that allow self-monitoring and correction. As Kneebone (2020) puts it, "being expert is something you do, not something you describe." The module's discussion of neuroplasticity encouraged me further: sustained, structured practice physically reorganises neural pathways, strengthening the connections a skill relies on. The online poker community helped too; study groups and shared hand reviews created the mutual encouragement that Tunariu (2022) describes as investing in relationships.

Perhaps the most transformative habit was post-session review. I would replay my marked hands without the solver (software that calculates theoretically sound strategy) first, asking, "What was I thinking? What did I miss?" Only then would I consult the software to compare. This maps onto Kolb (1984)'s experiential learning cycle: the session was concrete experience; self-review was reflective observation; identifying patterns in my errors was abstract conceptualisation; applying lessons in the next session was active experimentation. I kept a "leak journal" (poker's term for recurring weaknesses), and over time noticed the same faults resurfacing, such as calling big river bets when every signal said fold. Poker complicated this process: its feedback is noisy, since good decisions can lose money and bad ones can win it. Learning to grade my decisions rather than my results demanded what Dweck (2006) calls a growth mindset: treating each lost buy-in as data, not as evidence of limitation (Lyons & Bandura, 2018).

Setting the Course: Goals and Self-Efficacy

In June, at the 10NL stakes, my progress stalled. Opponents no longer handed money away with wild bluffs; the aggression that had beaten the smallest stakes was met with patient, solid play, and my winnings flatlined for three weeks. The frustration was real: I was studying daily yet seeing no improvement, and I caught myself making excuses ("I am running bad," "he always has it against me") rather than examining my own approach. Poker makes such excuses seductive; variance offers a ready-made alibi for every loss. This was precisely the cognitive dissonance Festinger (1957) describes, and my excuse-making was a form of the denial of responsibility that Gosling, Denizeau and Oberlé (2006) identify as a mode of dissonance reduction. I turned instead to goal-setting theory. Locke and Latham (2002) demonstrate that specific, challenging goals produce higher performance than vague intentions to "do your best." I had been telling myself to "beat the game," which is functionally no goal at all. I restructured using the SMART framework (Locke & Latham, 2013): a target of 25NL by mid-July, contingent on maintaining a forty buy-in bankroll, with weekly sub-goals (review fifty marked hands; drill one positional range; study one strategic concept).

The module lecture distinguished three goal types: process goals (actions taken), performance goals (standards against one's own past), and outcome goals (competitive results). Process goals proved most effective, especially in poker, where short-term outcomes lie partly outside one's control. Committing to "no session without reviewing the last one" or "stop playing after losing two buy-ins" created consistency that monetary targets could not sustain. This aligns with Deci and Ryan (1985)'s self-determination theory: process goals preserved autonomy and intrinsic motivation, whereas fixating on the money graph made each downswing feel threatening. Whitmore (1992)'s GROW model offered a complementary self-coaching scaffold; I periodically assessed my Goal, Reality, Options, and Will, keeping training purposeful. Dr Jo Perkins' guest lecture on the psychological advantage reinforced this through the WHAT/WHY/HOW framework: knowing *what* I wanted (beating 50NL), *why* it mattered to me (self-challenge and the judgement I will need in markets, not the money itself), and *how* I would structure my path (daily process goals and weekly review).

As I moved up through 25NL, something shifted. Bandura (1997) describes self-efficacy as belief in one's capacity to execute the behaviours necessary for specific outcomes. Each stake I beat reinforced the belief that the next was attainable. I also became more intentional about time, drawing on Osin and Boniwell (2024)'s concept of positive time use to structure sessions around self-congruence and mastery rather than raw volume: I played when fresh and stopped when tired. Zimbardo and Boyd (1999)'s balanced time perspective helped me hold present enjoyment and future orientation simultaneously, sustaining motivation without burnout.

Finding Flow Under Pressure

The August tournament remains vivid: my first live event, a small buy-in weekly tournament, real chips and real faces instead of avatars. When we reached the final table, I noticed the familiar symptoms: a quickened heartbeat, a dry mouth, unsteady hands as I moved my chips, a voice repeating, "don't throw this away." These correspond to what Kenny (2011) describes as cognitive and somatic dimensions of performance anxiety. The Yerkes-Dodson law posits that moderate arousal enhances performance, but beyond an optimal point the relationship inverts. The Individual Zones of Optimal Functioning framework refines this: the task is not to eliminate arousal but to find one's own functional band. I paused between hands and practised the cyclic sighing technique described by Balban et al. (2023): a double inhale through the nose followed by a prolonged exhale. Five seconds. My shoulders dropped. Their research shows this breathwork reduces physiological arousal more effectively than mindfulness meditation.

As the field shrank, something shifted. I stopped thinking about the prize money; my attention narrowed to stack sizes, ranges, and the players in front of me. Time distorted; four hours felt like one. Csikszentmihalyi (1990) characterises this as flow: action and awareness merge, the performer experiences control and intrinsic reward, and self-consciousness falls away. The challenge matched my skill level, a core precondition for flow, and months of practice had built the mental representations (A. Ericsson & Pool, 2016) to engage at this depth. Through Kahneman (2011)'s dual-process lens, flow in poker resembles the trained performer bypassing effortful System 2 deliberation for intuitive pattern recognition (System 1) refined through structured practice. Fredrickson (2001)'s broaden-and-build theory adds that confidence, accumulated through small successes, had broadened my thought-action repertoire, enabling creative possibilities rather than fear-driven caution.

I finished fourth of the eighty-two, proud of the result and clear-eyed about what it meant: the three players who outlasted me knew things I do not yet know. Yet the deeper insight was not the placing; it was about managing my internal state. Midway through the final table I lost a huge pot to plain bad luck, the kind of hand that once tipped me into tilt (the spiral of reckless, anger-driven play that follows a painful loss). I felt frustration rise, named it, and breathed. Lazarus and Folkman (1984)'s transactional model distinguishes problem-focussed coping (changing the stressor) from emotion-focussed coping (regulating the emotional response). I employed both: the decision framework was problem-focussed; the breathing was emotion-focussed. Tunariu (2019) observes that positive and negative emotions coexist in dialectic relationship; the frustration did not vanish, but engagement coexisted with it, allowing the "undoing effect" (Fredrickson, 2001) to prevent it from overwhelming. As R.D. Laing observed, "the range of what we think and do is limited by what we fail to notice"; self-awareness, the deliberate practice of noticing one's internal state (van Nieuwerburgh, 2020), was the skill that held everything together.

Looking Forward: What I Have Learned About Myself as a Performer

This journey revealed three things about myself as a performer. First, I had operated under what Dweck (2006) would recognise as a fixed mindset: the assumption that "card sense" was innate. Deliberate practice (K. A. Ericsson et al., 1993) reframed ability as constructed through sustained effort. Confronting the dissonance between "I am not talented" and the evidence of improvement forced a revision of cognition (Festinger, 1957); as Draycott and Dabbs (1998) observe, individuals reduce dissonance through varied cognitive adjustments; poker's variance meant resisting two temptations at once, explaining away losses as bad luck and claiming wins as pure skill. Second, I perform best with clear, self-set process goals rather than externally imposed outcome targets (Locke & Latham, 2002; Deci & Ryan, 1985). Third, my relationship with pressure is one of calibration, not avoidance: I perform best when arousal is managed rather than suppressed (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990; Balban et al., 2023).

These insights extend beyond poker; they point directly at the career I am preparing for. Trading, like poker, rewards disciplined decisions only on average and punishes emotional ones immediately, and the habits I built at the tables (grading decisions rather than outcomes, managing risk in fixed units, regulating arousal before acting) are the intuitions I most want to carry into markets. Looking ahead, I commit to three specific actions. First, I will apply Kolb (1984)'s experiential learning cycle to academic work, maintaining a weekly reflective journal mirroring my poker "leak journal." Second, I will use the GROW model (Whitmore, 1992) as a self-coaching framework each term, with SMART goals for academic and personal development. Third, I will integrate cyclic sighing (Balban et al., 2023) as a pre-performance routine, recognising that arousal regulation is transferable and trainable. The most unexpected outcome of that August tournament was not the finish itself, but the discovery that performance is less about the cards one is dealt and more about the deliberate, self-aware choices one makes in playing them.

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